

BITES AND STINGS

Give urgent attention to the patient with a bite/sting and any of:

- **Snake bite** (even if bite marks not seen) or venom in eyes
- If sudden generalised itch/rash, face/tongue swelling, wheeze, difficulty breathing, BP < 90/60, dizziness/collapse, abdominal pain or vomiting, check for anaphylaxis $\hookrightarrow$ 20.
- Weakness, drooping eyelids, difficulty swallowing and speaking, double vision
- Animal/human bite with any of: multiple bites, deep/large wound, loss of tissue, involving joint/bone, temperature $\geq$ 38°C or pus
- BP < 90/60
- Excessive or pulsatile bleeding

Manage and refer:

- If **snake bite or venom in eyes**:
 - Keep patient calm and still. Remove jewellery and immobilise bitten limb.
 - If venom in eyes: irrigate eye thoroughly for at least 20 minutes with water or **sodium chloride 0.9%**. If available, instil 1 drop **tetracaine 1%** eye drops before irrigating.
 - Clean bite with **chlorhexidine 0.05%** solution. Avoid applying tourniquet or sucking out venom.
 - Discuss pain management and need for antivenom with local poison helpline $\hookrightarrow$ 178.
- If excessive or pulsatile bleeding, apply direct pressure and elevate limb. If bleeding severe and persists, apply tourniquet above injury.
- If BP < 90/60, give **sodium chloride 0.9%** 1L IV rapidly, repeat until systolic BP > 90. Continue 1L 6 hourly. Stop if breathing worsens.
- Remove loose/dead skin. Clean wound with **chlorhexidine 0.05%** or **povidone iodine 10%** solution and irrigate under running water for 10 minutes. Avoid suturing the wound.
- Give **tetanus toxoid** 0.5mL IM if none in past 5 years.

Approach to the patient with a bite/sting not needing urgent attention

Human or animal bite/s

- Remove loose/dead skin. Clean wound with **chlorhexidine 0.05%** or **povidone iodine 10%** solution and irrigate under running water for 10 minutes.
- Avoid suturing puncture wounds.
- If animal bite, consider rabies post-exposure prophylaxis:
 - If bite/scratch with visible blood, licking of eyes/mouth/broken skin by a dog, cat, mongoose, jackal, cattle or goat; or any contact with a bat:
 - Inject **rabies immunoglobulin** 20IU/kg at the site of the bite *and*
 - Inject **rabies vaccine** 1 ampoule IM into deltoid muscle (not buttock). Repeat vaccine on days 3, 7 and 14 (if impaired immunity¹, also give a 5th dose on day 28).
 - If scratch with no visible blood, give rabies vaccine only as above.
 - If rabies immunoglobulin or vaccine unavailable, refer. If unsure, contact rabies hotline for advice $\hookrightarrow$ 178.
- Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days.
- If bite punctured the skin with visible bleeding, bite to hand or from human or bat: give **amoxicillin/clavulanic acid** 875/125mg 12 hourly for 5 days. If severe penicillin allergy², give instead **azithromycin** 500mg daily for 3 days and **metronidazole**³ 400mg 8 hourly for 5 days.
- If human bite, severe enough to cause bleeding, also assess need for hepatitis B post-exposure prophylaxis (PEP) $\hookrightarrow$ 108. Risk of HIV transmission through biting is negligible and HIV PEP not needed.
- If bite infected and no response to antibiotics within 48 hours, refer.

Insect/spider/scorpion sting or bite/s

- Remove stinger. Clean wound with soap and water. Apply ice pack for pain/swelling.
- If severe pain, redness, swelling or itch:
 - Give **chlorphenamine** 4mg 6-8 hourly for up to 5 days.
 - Apply **calamine lotion** as needed.
 - Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days.
- If spider bite, advise patient to return if signs of infection (skin red, warm, painful) and give **flucloxacillin** 500mg 6 hourly for 5 days. If severe penicillin allergy², give instead **azithromycin** 500mg daily for 3 days.
- If very painful scorpion sting, inject **lignocaine 2%** 2mL around site.
- If hypersensitivity response to insect bites - red raised bump/s that blister and heal with hyperpigmentation (darkened skin), **papular urticaria** likely: apply **hydrocortisone 1%** daily for 5 days.
- If long-term itch, give **cetirizine** 10mg once daily.
- Advise to reduce exposure to insects:
 - Treat pets, use bed nets, wash bedding, use insect repellents.
 - Clear away puddles of water around house.

If human/animal/spider bite or scorpion sting, give **tetanus toxoid** 0.5mL IM if none in past 5 years.

¹Known with HIV, diabetes or cancer, pregnant or receiving chemotherapy or corticosteroids. ²History of angioedema, anaphylaxis or urticaria. ³Advise no alcohol until 24 hours after last dose of metronidazole.